To Obey Is Better Than Sacrifice

God wants wholehearted obedience more than religious activity; partial obedience, excused and blamed on others, is still disobedience.

Main passage	1 Samuel 15:13-23 (KJV)
Topic	Obedience
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Partial obedience is disobedience	7 min
Teaching point 2: Excuses and blame	7 min
Teaching point 3: God wants obedience more than sacrifice	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask parents in the class: "Have your children ever 'mostly' obeyed you? Cleaned most of their room, or done the homework except for the hard part?" Ask: "Does 'mostly' count as obeying?" Today we see a king who mostly obeyed God, and what God thought of it.

Scripture (3 min)

1 Samuel 15:13-23

13 And Samuel came to Saul: and Saul said unto him, Blessed be thou of the LORD: I have performed the commandment of the LORD. 14 And Samuel said, What meaneth then this bleating of the sheep in mine ears, and the lowing of the oxen which I hear? 15 And Saul said, They have brought them from the Amalekites: for the people spared the best of the sheep and of the oxen, to sacrifice unto the LORD thy God; and the rest we have utterly destroyed. 16 Then Samuel said unto Saul, Stay, and I will tell thee what

the LORD hath said to me this night. And he said unto him, Say on. [17] And Samuel said, When thou wast little in thine own sight, wast thou not made the head of the tribes of Israel, and the LORD anointed thee king over Israel? [18] And the LORD sent thee on a journey, and said, Go and utterly destroy the sinners the Amalekites, and fight against them until they be consumed. [19] Wherefore then didst thou not obey the voice of the LORD, but didst fly upon the spoil, and didst evil in the sight of the LORD? [20] And Saul said unto Samuel, Yea, I have obeyed the voice of the LORD, and have gone the way which the LORD sent me, and have brought Agag the king of Amalek, and have utterly destroyed the Amalekites. [21] But the people took of the spoil, sheep and oxen, the chief of the things which should have been utterly destroyed, to sacrifice unto the LORD thy God in Gilgal. [22] And Samuel said, Hath the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. [23] For rebellion is as the sin of witchcraft, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry. Because thou hast rejected the word of the LORD, he hath also rejected thee from being king.

Read the passage aloud, with readers for Samuel and Saul if possible.

Background (5 min)

Saul was Israel's first king. He began humbly. Samuel reminds him that he was "little in thine own sight" (v. 17). Earlier he had already disobeyed by offering a sacrifice he was told to wait for (13:8-14). In chapter 15 God, through Samuel, commanded Saul to bring judgment on the Amalekites, the people who had attacked Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 17:8-16; Deuteronomy 25:17-19), and to take no plunder.

Saul won the battle but kept King Agag alive and kept the best of the livestock. Then he built a monument to himself (v. 12). When Samuel arrived, Saul greeted him by announcing, "I have performed the commandment of the LORD."

Teacher note: The command to destroy the Amalekites troubles many readers today. It was a specific act of judgment on a particular nation at a particular time and is not a pattern for God's people now. The lesson's focus, like the passage's, is on Saul's response to God's word.

Teaching point 1: Partial obedience is disobedience (7 min)

Saul claimed full obedience while the bleating of the sheep gave him away (v. 14). He had done the parts of the command that suited him and skipped the rest. God did not grade him on a curve. Choosing which parts of God's word to obey means we, not God, are really in charge.

Supporting verses

1 Samuel 15:13-15: And Samuel came to Saul: and Saul said unto him, Blessed be thou of the LORD: I have performed the commandment of the LORD. And Samuel said, What meaneth then this bleating of the sheep in mine ears, and the lowing of the oxen which I hear? And Saul said, They have brought them from the Amalekites: for the people spared the best of the sheep and of the oxen, to sacrifice unto the LORD thy God; and the rest we have utterly destroyed.

James 2:10: For whosoever shall keep the whole law, and yet offend in one point, he is guilty of all.

Luke 6:46: And why call ye me, Lord, Lord, and do not the things which I say?

> *"Saul was either blinded by a partial and delusive self-love, or he was, in his declaration to Samuel, acting the part of a bold and artful hypocrite."*
>
> — Robert Jamieson, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Samuel 15:13-23

Handout blanks (answers)

Saul said, "I have **performed** the commandment of the LORD."

Choosing which parts of God's word to obey is still **disobedience**.

Teaching point 2: Excuses and blame (7 min)

Twice Saul blamed "the people" (vv. 15, 21), and he gave a religious excuse: the animals were for sacrifice. Matthew Henry notes how quickly those who justify themselves blame others. Real repentance says "I have sinned" without "but."

Supporting verses

1 Samuel 15:15-21 (read from the Bible)

Genesis 3:12-13: And the man said, The woman whom thou gavest to be with me, she gave me of the tree, and I did eat. And the LORD God said unto the woman, What is this that thou hast done? And the woman said, The serpent beguiled me, and I did eat.

Proverbs 28:13: He that covereth his sins shall not prosper: but whoso confesseth and forsaketh them shall have mercy.

> *"Those that are willing to justify themselves are commonly very forward to condemn others, and to lay the blame upon any rather than take it to themselves."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:10-23

> *"Thus he endeavors to excuse the people."*
>
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:21

Handout blanks (answers)

Saul blamed the **people** for keeping the sheep.

Real repentance says "I have sinned" without a "**but**."

Teaching point 3: God wants obedience more than sacrifice (7 min)

"Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams" (v. 22). Sacrifices were commanded by God. But religious activity cannot make up for a disobedient heart. Samuel compares stubborn rebellion to witchcraft and idolatry, because it puts our will in God's place. For Christians, obedience flows from love: "If ye love me, keep my commandments" (John 14:15).

Supporting verses

1 Samuel 15:22-23: And Samuel said, Hath the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. For rebellion is as the sin of witchcraft, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry. Because thou hast rejected the word of the LORD, he hath also rejected thee from being king.

Micah 6:6-8: Wherewith shall I come before the LORD, and bow myself before the high God? shall I come before him with burnt offerings, with calves of a year old? Will the LORD be pleased with thousands of rams, or with ten thousands of rivers of oil? shall I give my firstborn for my transgression, the fruit of my body for the sin of my soul? He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?

John 14:15: If ye love me, keep my commandments.

> *"Is not obedience to the will of God the end of all religion, of its rites, ceremonies, and sacrifices?"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:22

Handout blanks (answers)

To obey is better than **sacrifice**.

Christian obedience flows from **love**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think Saul kept the best animals and King Agag?

Pride, greed, the people's pressure, wanting a trophy. He valued what looked good to him above God's word.

2. What "religious" excuses do we use to cover disobedience?

Doing good things to avoid the thing God asked; "God understands"; busyness in church instead of obedience at home.

3. Why is blaming others so natural, and what does it cost us?

It protects our pride; it keeps us from repentance and damages relationships.

4. How is obedience out of love different from obedience out of fear or duty?

Love obeys gladly and wholeheartedly; fear or bare duty tends toward the minimum and toward excuses.

Application (3 min)

Ask God to show you one area where you have been "mostly" obeying him. Name it honestly, without excuses, and take one concrete step of full obedience this week.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord God, forgive us for the times we have done what suited us and called it obedience. Forgive our excuses and our blaming. Give us hearts that love you and hearken to your voice, for to obey is better than sacrifice. Help us follow you fully, in the strength of Jesus, who was obedient to the Father in all things. Amen.

Sources quoted

Robert Jamieson, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on 1 Samuel 15:13-23

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:10-23

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:21

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on 1 Samuel 15:22

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